

Chapter 74_1 - Feathers

The vase behind her stirred up white smoke and dust, blowing her dark hair, the strands flying up from behind to fall on her shoulders. Only then did Chu Qingqiu realize she had lost her composure. Her expression became dazed as she lowered her head to look at the crystal bright powder scattered on the floor.

Her chest rose and fell gently, her delicate throat rolling up and down.

"My apologies." Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes and spoke, turning her palm to sweep away the mess on the floor.

Jiang Li, who had been startled, now supported her chest and showed a smile again, sighing helplessly: "Divine Venerable has reached this state, yet still wants to hide your feelings?"

"Don't you know that some things, no matter how calm and composed your nature, cannot be concealed?"

Chu Qingqiu said nothing more. She supported herself on the table edge and sat down. Jiang Li, reading the situation wisely, bid her farewell and turned to leave the room, leaving only Chu Qingqiu alone.

Along with what seemed to be violent heartbeats echoing in the beams.

Chu Qingqiu recited the Heart Calming Formula several times before suppressing her heartbeat. She opened her eyes to look at the lush greenery outside the window, feeling dejected.

Jiang Li was right. She had already broken the Emotionless Path, so without the blessing of that cultivation method, how could a person be completely without emotions and desires, especially when facing one's beloved? Even if she recited the Heart Calming Formula ten thousand times, it still couldn't resist.

She thought she could endure, but when she saw Jiuying approach Ning Fuyi, even though she knew it was Jiuying's trick, she still felt unbearably bitter.

She removed the jade bracelet from her wrist, gripping it tightly in her palm, then raised her hand to close the window.

Without the coverage of daylight, only dim darkness remained in the room, and a woman alone in the shadows.

Ning Fuyi was half-dragged, half-pulled back to Pearl Light Pavilion by Jiuying. When her toes touched the ground, she finally pushed the person away and reclaimed her arm.

"What are you doing!" Ning Fuyi looked down and tugged at her clothes, dispelling the goosebumps that had risen on her body.

"What am I doing? Proving it to you. Didn't you see your Divine Venerable's expression just now? Cold as ice that's been frozen in the sky for thousands of years." Jiuying caressed her smooth arms, pretending to shiver.

Ning Fuyi averted her gaze: "So what? She's always been like that."

"Are you truly clueless or pretending to be? Forget it, forget it. I can't explain clearly to you, this green girl. You'll understand in the future, but I'm afraid it might be too late by then." Jiuying crossed her arms.

"What do you mean by too late?" Ning Fuyi keenly caught the implication in Jiuying's words.

"Too late means too late. I, Jiuying, keep my word - what I've promised others cannot be spoken of." Jiuying's eyes sparkled with a smile, then she waved at her. "I'm too lazy to manage your affairs. I'm going to find a tree to rest."

Ning Fuyi watched her graceful retreating figure, her phoenix eyes narrowing. One after another, they all had things to hide from her, saying nothing to her, leaving her confused about everything.

"Jiuying!" Ning Fuyi suddenly called out, her figure transforming into points of light to block Jiuying's path. "Do you have any more feathers?"

Jiuying stopped in her tracks, protecting herself with both hands, looking suspicious: "What do you want my feathers for? Besides, I'm a qilin¹, not a phoenix - where would I get feathers?"

"I have my uses." Ning Fuyi's gaze swept over her body. "Those blue feathers you used to contact Qiuyi - where did they come from?"

"Oh, those." Jiuying understood. "Those are transformed from my scales, very precious indeed."

She lazily took out her feather fan and plucked two blue feathers shimmering with seven-colored light from it, handing them to Ning Fuyi.

When Ning Fuyi reached out to take them, she pulled the feathers back: "Hey, such precious things can't be given for free - there must be an exchange."

"Exchange for what?"

"I sleep in the bed tonight too." Jiuying smiled sweetly.

Ning Fuyi opened her palm: "Deal."

At nightfall, the disciples of Pearl Light Pavilion had all entered dreamland, and Jiuying was also lying on Ning Fuyi's bed snoring softly, with Ping'an lying on her stomach, making Jiuying's snores intermittent.

A dim lamp was lit on the long table outside the bedroom, illuminating only a small patch of the table. Moonlight outside the window was bright, casting mottled flower shadows on the walls.

Ning Fuyi hadn't slept. Taking advantage of everyone being asleep, she placed Jiuying's blue feathers in front of her. The ink on her brush tip had dried somewhat before she finally wrote a few characters.

"Are you asleep?"

At dusk, she had already sent Ping'an to deliver another blue feather to Chu Qingqiu, making communication more convenient.

She stared at the square night sky outside the window for a while, lost in thought, when the blue feather suddenly emitted seven-colored light, and a character appeared.

The corner of Ning Fuyi's mouth curved up as she lowered her head to look.

"No."

Just like Chu Qingqiu's usual speaking style - economical with words. Ning Fuyi smiled, using her brush tip to prop up her chin, and continued writing: "Why isn't the Divine Venerable resting?"

This time Chu Qingqiu replied extremely quickly: "Not tired. What matter?"

Ning Fuyi's fingertips lightly tapped the table surface, pondering for a moment, then wrote: "I didn't have a chance to speak during the day, but I have a guess about that person's identity."

"Mm." came the reply from the other side.

Ning Fuyi raised her dark brows slightly and continued writing diligently: "The Divine Venerable isn't surprised?"

"If it's someone from within the sect, then I think our guesses are the same." Chu Qingqiu's characters appeared one by one, each stroke neat and orderly.

"But don't speak of this matter to anyone for now, in case there are other accomplices within the sect."

"I understand." Ning Fuyi wrote.

After the writing faded, there was no more reply from Chu Qingqiu's side. Ning Fuyi propped up her chin and waited for a long time, feeling inexplicably stifled.

Jiuying's words echoed faintly in her mind again. She tapped the table with more force, feeling irritated and restless.

In her previous life, she had initially feared Chu Qingqiu, thinking her an unapproachable immortal paragon. Later, this fear was suppressed by resentment. After falling into the demonic path, she was muddled and confused, remembering nothing but hatred.

But in this life, since her rebirth, Chu Qingqiu had never left her sight, protecting her everywhere at the cost of her own life. No matter how hard-hearted she was, her heart could no longer remain so cold and hard.

Ning Fuyi could sense that some things deeply embedded in her soul - cruelty, resentment, or indifference - had undergone more or less transformation, or had dissipated entirely.

But what Jiuying spoke of was still absurd to her.

The candle was almost burned out, and the candlelight flickered in Ning Fuyi's eyes, the flame making her brows and eyes appear somewhat bewitching.

She suddenly picked up her brush again and wrote deliberately: "Divine Venerable, my head hurts a little."

This time the blue feather began emitting a faint light continuously, but no writing appeared for a long time. Just when Ning Fuyi thought the blue feather was malfunctioning, a line of text appeared.

"Open the door."

After Ning Fuyi saw what Chu Qingqiu had written, her heartstrings immediately trembled. She put down her brush and rose to open the door.

The wisteria flowers hanging from the courtyard wall rustled in the wind, and Ning Fuyi felt her heart trembling along with the flower shadows.

The woman standing outside the door, her shoulders touched by moonlight, her clothing merged with the moon's radiance, her glass hairpin and the glass at the corner of her eyes reflecting light together, sparkling brilliantly in the dim night.

Ning Fuyi quickly held her breath and coughed twice to stop her wildly beating heart.

Her intention had been to find a topic to make Chu Qingqiu reply, but she hadn't expected her to actually appear at the door in the night.

"Divine, Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi smiled awkwardly.

"Your head hurts again?" Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice. She raised two fingers, about to summon immortal power, when Ning Fuyi quickly stepped back and waved her hands repeatedly.

"It hurt a little just now, but it doesn't hurt anymore." She tried to brush it off. "Perhaps, perhaps it was the cool night wind."

Chu Qingqiu said nothing, only showing slight furrows between her brows, then hummed in acknowledgment.

Ning Fuyi felt as if all her thoughts had been seen through, lowering her head to touch her nose.

Fortunately, Chu Qingqiu didn't reproach her much. Her gaze followed the door crack to look inside: "Where is Jiuying?"

"Sleeping with Ping'an." Ning Fuyi breathed a sigh of relief and answered.

"You have a place for her here?" Chu Qingqiu asked again.

"She's sleeping on my bed. I sleep late." Ning Fuyi smiled.

"Sleeping on your bed?" The furrows between Chu Qingqiu's brows deepened.

"The Divine Venerable need not worry. I'm planning to move to the wooden house my mother left me tomorrow. That way it'll be more convenient with Ping'an and Jiuying." Ning Fuyi said.

"Who's worried about you?" Chu Qingqiu said indifferently, then turned and walked down the mountain. Her hairpin brushed past the wisteria flowers, making the flowers in the moonlight seem like wind-blown pearl curtains.

Ning Fuyi covered the smile at the corner of her lips, closed the door, then quickened her steps to catch up.

"Regarding that demon clan person, what does the Divine Venerable plan to do?" Ning Fuyi said seriously.

"That person is even more powerful than you imagine. Even if we guess who he is, we cannot act rashly. After all, the other five sect masters and elders are all in the Eastern Wasteland dealing with the Eastern Wasteland Konghou². If we provoke him to expose his identity now, our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate would be isolated and helpless." Chu Qingqiu said.

"But isn't the Divine Venerable afraid he'll make the first move?" Ning Fuyi frowned. "After all, the situation in the Eastern Wasteland is critical. Now is a good opportunity to attack us."

"When soldiers come, we'll block them; when water comes, we'll cover it with earth. If he really comes, I have my own methods." Chu Qingqiu said, her cheek slightly turned, but not looking at Ning Fuyi. "You needn't think about this matter anymore. Healing your injuries is what's important."

Upon hearing this, Ning Fuyi suddenly quickened her steps, turned around, and blocked Chu Qingqiu's path, forcing her to stop abruptly and look up to meet her gaze.

"What are you doing?"

"What method does the Divine Venerable speak of?" Ning Fuyi looked at her and asked.

Before Chu Qingqiu could speak, Ning Fuyi narrowed her brows: "Don't say I needn't ask again. That demon clan person has repeatedly targeted me. I can't always have friends and you taking risks for me."

"I can protect you all in the future too." Ning Fuyi lowered her voice.

"Do you think that by forming a contract with a divine beast and possessing a divine sword, you can deal with that person?" Chu Qingqiu said, gently shaking her head. "Overestimating yourself."

"I know that in the Divine Venerable's eyes, my magical power is weak and hardly useful." Being spoken to in such a tone made Ning Fuyi feel stifled, but she rarely showed it, continuing instead: "But I'm not a reckless person. I just want to face the demon clan together with you, not hide behind you."

Chu Qingqiu soon stopped meeting her gaze, only looking at the dark mountain shadows in the distance. After a long time, she said: "The Waning Moon Array."

"The Waning Moon Array - the formation you used to kill that ancient evil spirit?" Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes slightly closed. "But your cultivation is only half remaining, and you still have old injuries. How can you set up the array?"

"The Waning Moon Array cannot be set by my power alone. When I killed that ancient evil spirit, I had Ning Changfeng's³ assistance. As long as I serve as the array's eye and other powerful cultivators set up the formation, we can ensure that demon clan person has no return."

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu was telling her everything frankly, Ning Fuyi's earlier frustration immediately dissipated in the wind. Her eyes also contained a smile as she stepped back to make way for Chu Qingqiu.

"Since the Divine Venerable already has a plan, then I'll listen to you." Ning Fuyi said.

"From now on, we'll need to find some trustworthy people to set up the formation together." Ning Fuyi's steps became lighter, emphasizing the word "we" heavily.

Chu Qingqiu looked at her trusting and joyful expression, secretly clenching her sleeve with one hand, a trace of guilt flashing in her eyes.

Since that night's conversation with Ning Fuyi, Chu Qingqiu had not seen her face for many days. In recent days, the blue feather occasionally flickered with light, but she would only glance at it before forcibly leaving.

She dared not approach her again - a single touch would disturb her heart.

Initially, Ning Fuyi had also come to her door, but Chu Qingqiu refused using the excuse of recuperation. Later, when Ning Fuyi stopped coming to Jingshan Palace, though Chu Qingqiu breathed a sigh of relief, her heart felt as if a piece was missing, and she would look toward the door from time to time with or without reason.

One day, unable to bear it any longer, she inquired with Qiuyi and learned that Ning Fuyi had gone down the mountain with Rong Jin, Liu Wenzhu, and others.

This left Chu Qingqiu stunned for a long time, and she became angry - angry that Ning Fuyi had hastily gone down the mountain when her headaches weren't yet cured, not knowing what for, and angry that Ning Fuyi hadn't even reported to her before leaving.

But then she remembered she had thrown the blue feather into a cabinet, so she didn't know who to be angry with.

On this day, the weather was fine, and large patches of sunlight fell into Jingshan Palace. Several little immortal attendants moved potted plants to bask in the sun in the garden, making the day, though nearly early autumn, look as vibrant as spring.

Jiang Li, holding two flowers to her nose, gracefully entered the door. She waved at Qiuyi, who was watering flowers, and smiled sweetly: "Where is your master?"

Qiuyi put down her wooden ladle, bowed to Jiang Li, and said: "Medical Immortal Jiang, Master is still in her room."

"She seems to have been in poor spirits these past few days. Medical Immortal Jiang, perhaps you should..."

"It's fine. I have good news to tell her." Jiang Li waved the flowers in her hand, beaming, then scattered her shawl and floated upstairs like an immortal.

She knocked on Chu Qingqiu's door: "Divine Venerable, what are you doing staying cooped up in your room on such a beautiful day? Come out and get some sun. Today is the Qixi Festival⁴ - it's very lively down the mountain!"

The room was quiet for a while before Chu Qingqiu's indifferent voice came through: "I'm feeling unwell. Medical Immortal, have Qiuyi take you down the mountain."

"Then the method I've finally thought of to cure the young sect master - I'll wait until I return from the mountain to report to the Divine Venerable." Jiang Li's eyes sparkled charmingly.

The door creaked open, and Chu Qingqiu stood coldly in the shadows.

"What method?"

Jiang Li almost laughed out loud. She covered her lips with her shawl and entered uninvited.

"Actually, the young sect master's condition is nothing more than caused by her sea of consciousness. If I could enter her sea of consciousness and sever the tree that's causing her pain, or prevent that tree from forcibly merging with her soul, that would be it." Jiang Li closed the door and lowered her voice.

"But didn't you say her sea of consciousness can't be entered?"

"Her sea of consciousness can't be entered because two forces repel each other, preventing others' divine consciousness from entering, while her own divine consciousness isn't strong enough to enter on its own."

"There's only one method in the world that can make another person's divine consciousness merge with hers." Jiang Li smiled slightly.

"What..." Chu Qingqiu spoke halfway before stopping, her usually composed face suddenly showing faint blushes.

Jiang Li extended one hand, symbolically covering her lips, and whispered: "That would be the method of dual cultivation⁵."

Footnotes:

¹ Qilin (麒麟) - A mythical Chinese creature, often called a Chinese unicorn, known as a benevolent beast

² Eastern Wasteland Konghou (东荒箜篌) - Konghou is a type of ancient Chinese harp; likely referring to a powerful entity or weapon

³ Ning Changfeng (宁长风) - Ning Fuyi's mother in her previous life

⁴ Qixi Festival (七夕) - Chinese Valentine's Day, the festival of the weaver girl and cowherd

⁵ Dual cultivation (双修) - A Daoist practice where partners cultivate together, often involving intimate spiritual and physical union to enhance cultivation